COPING STRATEGIES FOR KIDS

Young children often struggle to manage their big feelings.

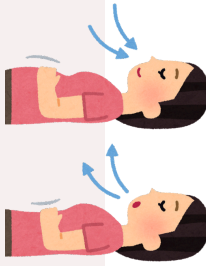
Practicing coping skills with them helps them learn more effective ways to deal with their emotions. Some skills will likely work better for them than others.

By trying out a variety of skills in different scenarios, you can help them create their own 'toolbox' of strategies to help them calm down in tough moments.

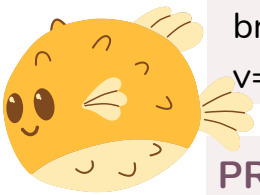
DEEP BREATHING

Taking long, slow 'belly breaths' helps our bodies and brains calm down. Here are some creative and fun ways to practice deep breathing with your child:

- Imagine smelling their favorite hot food (e.g., pizza, ramen, hot chocolate) while breathing in and cooling it off as they breathe out
- Lay on the floor, have them put a small toy on belly, and watch the toy go up and down with deep breaths
- Blow bubbles or into a pinwheel



Resource: Child-friendly video on how to practice deep breathing like a puffer fish - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gLbK0o9Bk7Q

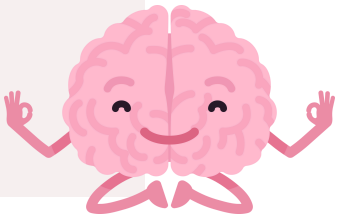


PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION

Tensing and releasing our muscles can help let go of stored up stress. Finding fun ways to tense and release muscles can increase kids' engagement with this activity, such as:

- Pretend to squeeze lemons to make lemonade (hands/arms)
- Pretend to be a turtle and stick your head in your shell (shoulders/neck)
- Pretend to dig your feet into sand/a mud puddle (legs)

Resource: Progressive Muscle Relaxation for Kids & Adults - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=aaTDNYjk-Gw



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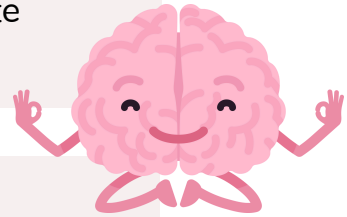
COPING STRATEGIES FOR KIDS

5 SENSES GROUNDING

Focusing on our five senses and our environment around us can shift our focus from intense emotions and thoughts. With your child, walk through these steps to bring them back to the present moment:



- Notice 5 things you can see (chair, table, lamp, etc.)
- Notice 4 things you can touch (shirt, chair, your hair, etc.)
- Notice 3 things you can hear (fan, people talking, car, etc.)
- Notice 2 things you can smell (lotion, shirt, etc.)
- Notice 1 thing you can taste (snack, water, pretend to “taste the air,” etc.)



POSITIVE COPING THOUGHTS

Our internal voice can be either positive or negative. The way that we think about challenging situations can affect how we feel and what we do.

- Identifying helpful thoughts in advance can help with replacing unhelpful thoughts and getting through tough moments
- Helping your child practice and remember these phrases (such as being part of a bedtime routine or putting a sticky note on the bathroom mirror) makes it become a habit.

Examples of coping thoughts for kids:



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COPING STRATEGIES FOR KIDS

5 SENSES SOOTHING

Flooding our senses with positive and/or intense sensations can help us cope with challenging emotions and thoughts. Here are a few ideas that may help your child:





- Touch: soft blanket/clothing, hug, warm or cold shower/hot or cold pack
- Listen to: music, nature sounds, hum a song
- Look at: soothing video (waterfall, campfire), favorite photos, through the window
- Smell: essential oil, lotion/candle, fresh outdoor air
- Taste: snack, flavorful drink, sour food/candy

Containing Challenging Feelings

Sometimes we experience thoughts and feelings about past challenging experiences at times when we don't have the bandwidth to think about/process it.

Visualization exercises can help your child practice 'containing' the emotions until they are in a time and place when they are ready to feel them.

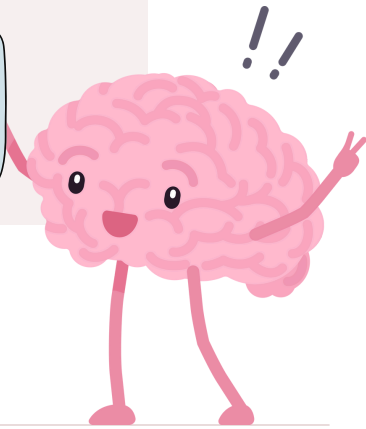
EXAMPLES



(ASU01, 2022)

- Container Exercise (EMDR for Kids) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bdjlk6JNx0k
- A similar strategy of 'throwing' your upset and angry feelings away is discussed in Bluey - "Stickbird" (S3 E41)





COPING STRATEGIES FOR KIDS

Positive Affirmations

Helping children develop a positive inner voice can help them navigate challenging experiences more effectively. The below videos are examples of positive affirmations for children:

1 Minute Morning Affirmations for Kids (Music with Ms Moretta)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lXjlhSiAgJg

Positive Affirmations Song for Kids (Super Sema)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mRkbBMIsovY



Meditation with Visualization

Using imagination to envision scenes can help children shift how they feel. This mountain-themed meditation may help them feel more grounded and settled in themselves:

Mountain Meditation for Children (InsightTimer)
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZIJ5KovxnV4